



FORTUNA ADMISSIONS
INSIDER'S TOP TIPS
FOR APPLYING TO
THE WHARTON SCHOOL

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ABOUT THE SCHOOL

Wharton Business School is part of the elite trinity often referred to as HSW. And if any of the top business schools has adjusted to a post-Lehman Brothers world it's Wharton. The entrepreneurial community has surged in the past six years, and the construction of a six-story entrepreneurial hub, Tangen Hall, offers further evidence of the ways Wharton continues to evolve beyond its roots in finance to also drive entrepreneurial innovation. The business school's success in incubating industry disruptors prompted Inc. magazine to dub the school "the spiritual center of the DTC startup movement."

The school can also claim among the highest percentage of women in a top MBA program, with an unprecedented seven years in a row when women made up at least 40% of the class. It's newly appointed dean, Erika James, will be first woman and person of color in its storied history. And the quality of admitted students is also on the rise, if measured by the average 730 GMAT score of the incoming class.

The introduction of a Team Based Discussion component to the MBA admissions has been well received by participants, and showcases the interaction and inclusive values that are a far cry from the outdated stereotype of a competitive student body. And the school's improving yield, which shows that more applicants who receive an offer to join the Wharton program are saying 'yes,' suggests that they are a good fit and prize a Wharton education over any other.

STRENGTHS AND SPECIALIZATIONS

General Management, Finance, Health Care, Entrepreneurship, Real Estate, Nonprofit/Social Responsibility, International Management, Economics, Big Data. Over 200 electives on offer.

INCOMING CLASS

Number of Applicants: 5,905 MBA Class Size: 856
Admissions Selectivity: 14.5% Yield: 67%
Total Tuition: \$162,756

POST-MBA CAREERS

Sector: Financial Services 35.8%; Consulting 25%; Technology 14.9%; Healthcare 4.3%; Starting Own Business (4%)

Top Recruiters incl.: Accenture, McKinsey, BCG, Bain & Co., BAML, Blackstone Group, Citi, Credit Suisse, Facebook, Deloitte, Amazon, Apple, Goldman Sachs, Google

Avg. Base Salary: \$135,716 Employment in 3 months: 98.4%

MBA RANKINGS

	2012	2013	2014	2015	2016	2017	2018	2019
BusinessWeek	3	3	2	5	6	6	2	6
Financial Times	3	3	3	2	4	3	2	3
Forbes	-	4	-	7	-	1	-	5
The Economist	10	10	9	8	12	-	4	4
US News	3	3	1	3	4	2	3	1

ADMISSIONS

Avg. Work Exp.: 5 yrs Avg. GMAT: 732 Avg. GPA: 3.6
Int'l Students: 30% Female Students: 46%

Deadlines for 2020-2021: R1 - Sep 15, '20 R2 - Jan 5, '21 R3 - March 31, '21

Sources: Wharton, BusinessWeek, Financial Times, US News



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ESSAYS 2020-2021

Essay Analysis: How to Tackle the Wharton Essays

By Dr. Judith Silverman Hodara

Judith served as a core member of admissions committees at the University of Pennsylvania for almost two decades, most recently as Acting Director at the Wharton School's MBA Program. She was also an Associate Director in the Office of Undergraduate Admissions at the University of Pennsylvania.

In its introduction to its two required essays, Wharton states, "The Admissions Committee wants get to know you on both a professional and personal level" – and it really means it.

Essay 1 asks: "What do you hope to gain professionally from the Wharton MBA?" (500 words)

This, of course, is the opportunity to connect your powerful and coherent career vision within the context of how the Wharton MBA – in particular – will set you up for success. In essence, Wharton is asking what you'll get out of being there.

Essay 2, new for the 2020-21 cycle: "Taking into consideration your background—personal, professional, and/or academic—how do you plan to make specific, meaningful contributions to the Wharton community?" (400 words)

The new second question is an invitation to serve up something more personal. It really allows you to reflect and offer additional information and insights that don't appear elsewhere in your application. The challenge is to do so in 400 words, which requires both profound self-awareness and profound understanding of the community you're hoping to join.

Here are three top tips to crafting a great response to the Wharton essays:

1. Create a unifying narrative across your essays.

Remember to consider both of your essay responses as part of a unifying narrative. Essay one is straightforward, asking for 500 words on, "What do you hope to gain professionally from the Wharton MBA?" So if the first question is asking what you'll get out of Wharton, the second question wants to know what will Wharton will get in return. This is a big bottom line for admissions: What are the forces that shape who you are, and how do they shape the kind of leader and community member you will be? The beauty of this kind of combination question is the opportunity to share an example from your background and connect it directly to your experience at Wharton.

2. Connect the dots for the admissions committee.

The specificity of the new question #2's wording signals that you should connect the dots for the admissions committee between where you are coming from and where you are heading. Unlike earlier iterations, there is little room for ambiguity and also a lot of room for backstory. The new essay question invites you to go deeper into clarifying how elements of your identity and background shape your awareness and why it matters going forward. Don't just reinforce a link to how your background will 'aid in my teamwork skills,' or how you've developed better communication skills, but share specifics with your reader that go deeper into who you are, what makes you unique and what you stand to offer. The Admissions Committee wants specifics.



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(Essay analysis, cont.)

Do you have a background in community organizing that lends itself directly to such activities at Wharton? Does your choice of academic study, or family background, or culture – influence what you have chosen to pursue professionally? In this question, Wharton is offering you a lot of leeway choosing what influence(s) to focus on. Get introspective and be discerning about what historical threads you choose to share and their significance, both for you and the future community with whom you hope to engage.

3. Prove you know the program as you answer the question.

This means writing from a deep understanding of Wharton's values and culture. With more than 860 students in any incoming class, Wharton is without a doubt team-based, but it's also community based. It's about being part of a much larger organism than your learning team or your cohort, and also discerning how your unique experiences will shape the experiences of many of your fellow students, the program and the institution writ large.

INTERVIEW - TEAM BASED DISCUSSION

In 2012, the Wharton Admissions office partnered with the Wharton Innovation group to launch a new evaluation method, the Team Based Discussion (TBD). If you are invited to interview, you will participate in a TBD with 5-6 other applicants during your scheduled session. The TBD will allow you the opportunity to interact with your fellow applicants through discourse involving real-world business scenarios, which will highlight how you approach and analyze specific situations. Your discussion will have a prompt and a purpose, and you will work towards a tangible outcome with your group. The TBD is additive and does not replace the opportunity for an individual exchange: There will be time allotted for a short one-on-one conversation with a member of the Admissions staff during the interview.

For specific insights and tips on this year's TBD, view Judith's article in Poets&Quants: [Wharton's Team-Based Discussion – What To Expect And How To Succeed](#)



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9 Top Tips for Acing Your Wharton Application

By Judith Silverman Hodara

Tip #1 - Demonstrating your team orientation

One of the common stereotypes is that Wharton is an “eat or be eaten” kind of environment. Contrary to popular belief, uber-competitive Wharton is actually home to an extremely collaborative and team-oriented learning environment. The utilization of learning clusters, cohorts, and teams (you may work with 15+ over your time in the program) provide a platform for collaboration and learning to lead through teamwork. Accordingly, your application needs to reflect your ability to actively contribute and thrive in these settings. Individuals who present themselves as lacking a team-orientation or having a leadership style that is closed, rather than facilitative, will be at a disadvantage in terms of being invited to interview and ultimately being granted admission.

Tip #2 - Balancing your professional & personal profile

Wharton does look at each applicant file holistically understanding that what you do for a living is not who you are or what you will bring to the community. You certainly would not want someone to consider you only by your profession, so it's a good idea to use some balance within the framework of your application. Your essay examples should reflect things that the committee may not know about you from outside the workplace, in addition to showcasing your professional skills. If you can keep in mind that you are a sum of about 10,000 parts, and show that in the application, the admissions officers will see that passion and connection too.

Tip #3 - Conveying your interest in Wharton

Choosing to focus on a particular field of interest in your application is key. Of course, applicants have a variety of interests that they intend to pursue during their MBA. However, in the application it may not be a good idea to be a generalist. Therefore you may want to speak specifically about a professor or a class or a club that interests you, and have them all be connected, so that there is a theme to your writing. With 200 other electives and an incredibly rich student life there are any number of ways to immerse yourself in the MBA experience so think about how you can contribute and make a difference.

Tip #4 - Adcom's view of non-traditional backgrounds

Wharton actively encourages applicants coming from non-traditional backgrounds to apply to the school. In addition to bringing a wealth of diversity to the classroom discussion from an industry perspective, applicants from this sector have often also had non- business undergraduate academic interests. This combination helps to add to the energy of the classroom and club interactions. With the breadth of the University of Pennsylvania's graduate programs, where students can take up to 4 classes outside of the Wharton program and receive credit, it is not surprising that many Wharton students take classes in other related fields that would further their career paths in non profit work, such as at the School of Education or School of Social Policy and Practice.



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Tip #5 - Undergrad degrees

While Wharton certainly has applicants from the top universities in the United States and abroad, what is probably more important than the name of the school or if it is public or private is how the candidate fared during their degree. In my tenure at Wharton, I saw a lot of applicants from lesser-known private schools or state schools who had really made a name for themselves both academically and in the campus community with leadership and engagement. Students who are coming from those schools bring so much to the MBA community and are sometimes the most involved and participatory members of the class. At the end of the day, going to a "brand name" is only as good as what you bring to that brand, and if you can bring a great deal of academic ability, as well as the ability to transform the community you're a part of, then you've got a great case to make for yourself.

Tip #6 - Value of extracurricular activities

The holistic review process at Wharton lends itself to the program's desire to bring in a class with top-notch candidates from many professional, educational, social and cultural backgrounds. They are also looking for individuals with personality (and a life outside of work!), who contribute to the diversity of the classroom and campus experience at Wharton. Believe it or not, who you are matters. Maybe you're passionate about a specific organization or cause and to this you devote much of your free time – or maybe it's triathlons, caring for family, or running a business. The moral of the story is whatever it is you love to do in your free time, highlight how that makes you unique. If the activity itself isn't so unique or glamorous, perhaps what differentiates your participation is why the activity is important to you. Don't be afraid to be yourself here.

Tip #7 - International students and limited overseas experience

Wharton certainly is one of the most international of the top US MBA programs; however, internationalism comes in many forms. Generally speaking, while experience abroad can certainly be a great addition to your resume, perhaps there are other ways to exhibit this kind of interest in the world around you. Perhaps you mention that there are certain courses or clubs that appeal to you precisely because of the international exposure you will receive. Or, you can think of ways within your current career to gain more cross-cultural experience even if you never have the opportunity to leave your home country. Both possibilities exhibit that you are "open" to the possibility of international exposure, and this "openness" is something that Wharton values highly.

Tip #8 - Presenting your career plans

It's important within the context of the application process to show that you have a career path in mind. Students who indicate that they have "so many ideas that they don't know where to start" come across as unfocused and non-directed.

The Wharton Vice Dean once famously said at Convocation, "If we only granted diplomas to those of you who had followed your suggested career paths from your applications, no one would actually graduate!" The beauty of a transformational business school education is that it does give you tremendous exposure to possibilities on a professional and personal level. However, Wharton admissions officers want to ensure that you can create a viable path to follow: understanding that while the actual industry and functions are variable, you should enter the program with a sense of purpose. Business school has been likened to drinking water from a fire-hose, and those who come in with no plan at all are frequently hosed down by the blast. It is advisable to give as much detail as you can about next steps in your career, showcasing that you understand what the Wharton program will allow you to do along the way.



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Tip #9 - Importance of a recommendation from alumni

While it's always "nice" to have a Wharton MBA (or any MBA) on your recommendation list, it's by no means a requirement of the admissions committee. Wharton does prefer a direct supervisor as one of your recommenders, who can speak to your contributions within the workplace, and compare you to your peers in the professional realm. If this person also went to Wharton, that's great. However, finding a Wharton graduate to write on your behalf just because they have the degree does not carry more weight in the perception of the admissions committee. As importantly, use your judgment in this decision-making process, as you think about your recommendation writers. You want to make sure to choose those who will be able to write about your candidacy with clarity and depth, regardless of their degrees.

More about Fortuna Admissions:

Fortuna Admissions is a dream team of former MBA Admissions Directors and Officers from the top-tier business schools, including Wharton, INSEAD, Harvard Business School, Stanford GSB, Kellogg, LBS, Chicago Booth, Columbia, NYU Stern, IE, Duke Fuqua, UCLA Anderson, Cornell Johnson, Yale SOM and Berkeley Haas.

As industry experts, we regularly provide commentary and analysis about b-school admissions for major media around the world. To read our full range of advice visit: [FortunaAdmissions.com](https://www.FortunaAdmissions.com)

With our unparalleled collective expertise, we are able to coach you to develop a clear vision of your goals for business school and beyond. We work closely with you throughout the application process and provide expert guidance at every stage to maximize your chances of admission to a top school.

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